

Friendzone isn't a dead end. It's where empathy and affection blossom

Between men and women there is no friendship possible. There is **passion**, **enmity**, worship, love, but no friendship," noted Oscar Wilde in *Lady Windermere's Fan*. In Bollywood speak, that would be "Ek ladka aur ladki kabhi dost nahin ho sakte" — a **dictum** generations of Indians have grown up with and that has been the default script for friendships between men and women in films and IRL (in real life): **Doomed**, **delicate**, and **perpetually** flirting with something "more". But a recent NYU Stern-Meta study, which **analysed** 1.8 billion friendships across nearly 200 countries, finally **bursts that bubble**. It **turns out** that men and women do **forge** genuine, deep friendships, especially in societies where gender equality is strong. And the more **liberated** a culture is from old-fashioned gender roles, the more natural it becomes for men and women to simply enjoy each other's company without a romantic **subtext**.

The **implications** are more **radical** than they appear — and **rooted in** the long **arc** of **feminism**. Given the deeply **entrenched** gender inequality, in the 18th century, early **feminists** like Mary Wollstonecraft **recast** friendship between the sexes as a **revolutionary** force — the emotional and **intellectual bedrock** of equal relationships, and the foundation of a happy marriage in which partners enjoyed more than just physical **compatibility**. It would take another century and another wave of feminism to get sex out of the way and push it into the **realm** of the **platonic** — not very successfully, **going by** popular culture. To **paraphrase** Nora Ephron's blockbuster *When Harry Met Sally*, "the sex part" still "gets in the way".

But what if it didn't? What if friendship between the sexes could finally **shrug off** its **nudge-nudge-wink-wink baggage**? When men and women meet as equals, they **model** respect, empathy, and emotional openness in workplaces, families, and communities. Sure, attraction can **flutter** in the background, but mature friendships absorb it with **grace**. As the study shows, affection doesn't have to moonlight as romance. Sometimes, it just shows up as **camaraderie**. And honestly, isn't that happily ever after enough?

[Practice Exercise]

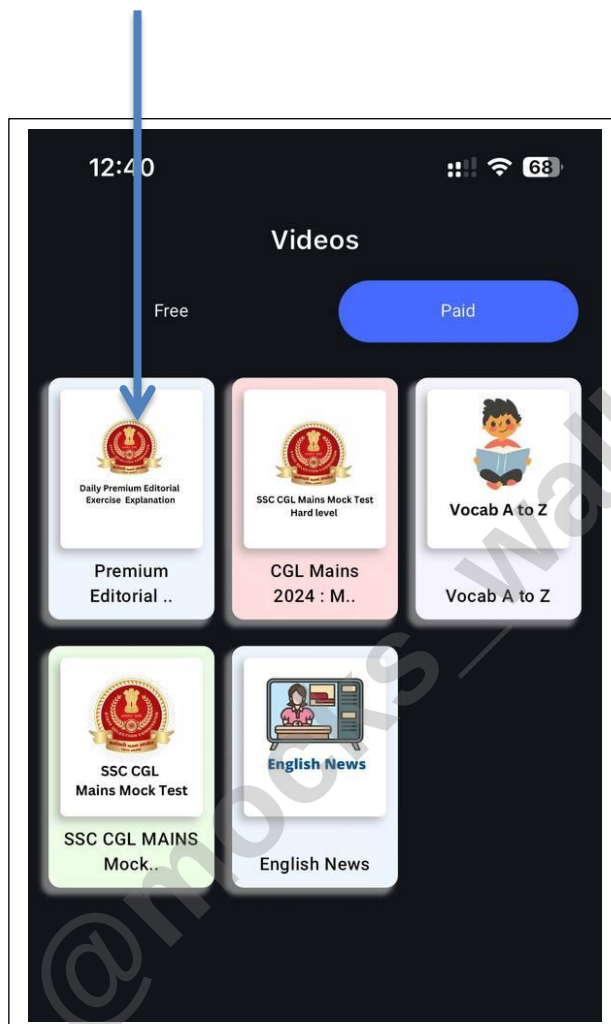
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- Recast (verb) - present or organize in a different form or style फिर से बनाना
- **Model** (verb) - take (someone admired or respected) as an example to follow or imitate.

Vocabulary

1. **A dead end** (noun) – blockage, impasse, standstill, obstacle, cul-de-sac अंतहीन स्थिति
2. **Empathy** (noun) – understanding, compassion, sympathy, sensitivity, kindness सहानुभूति
3. **Affection** (noun) – love, fondness, care, warmth, tenderness स्नेह
4. **Blossom** (verb) – bloom, develop, grow, flourish, unfold खिलना
5. **Passion** (noun) – desire, emotion, intensity, ardour, fervour जुनून
6. **Enmity** (noun) – hostility, hatred, animosity, resentment, bitterness दुश्मनी
7. **Dictum** (noun) – saying, proverb, maxim, adage, command उक्ति
8. **Doomed** (adjective) – cursed, condemned, fated, hopeless, ill-fated अवश्यभावी विनाशित
9. **Delicate** (adjective) – fragile, sensitive, tender, subtle, dainty नाजुक
10. **Perpetually** (adverb) – continuously, constantly, endlessly, always, eternally लगातार
11. **Analyse** (verb) – examine, study, investigate, assess, evaluate विश्लेषण करना
12. **Burst that bubble** (phrase) – shatter illusion, reveal truth, disillusion, expose reality, break belief भ्रम तोड़ना
13. **Turn out** (phrasal verb) – prove, happen, result, emerge, end up साबित होना
14. **Forge** (verb) – build, create, develop, establish, form निर्माण करना
15. **Liberated** (adjective) – free, independent, open-minded, progressive, unshackled मुक्त
16. **Subtext** (noun) – underlying meaning, hidden message, implication, nuance, suggestion अंतर्निहित अर्थ
17. **Implication** (noun) – consequence, effect, meaning, inference, suggestion निहितार्थ
18. **Radical** (adjective) – extreme, revolutionary, progressive, drastic, transformative क्रांतिकारी
19. **Root** (in) (verb) – base, originate, establish, derive, embed आधारित होना
20. **Arc** (noun) – path, curve, storyline, direction, progression क्रमिक प्रवाह
21. **Feminism** (noun) – women's rights, gender equality, female empowerment, liberation, egalitarianism नारीवाद
22. **Entrenched** (adjective) – established, fixed, ingrained, rooted, deep-seated गहराई से जमी हुई
23. **Revolutionary** (adjective) – groundbreaking, radical, transformative, reformatory, innovative क्रांतिकारी
24. **Intellectual** (adjective) – mental, rational, cerebral, thoughtful, analytical बौद्धिक
25. **Bedrock** (noun) – foundation, basis, core, groundwork, support मूल आधार

26. **Compatibility** (noun) – harmony, agreement, suitability, match, alignment अनुकूलता
27. **Realm** (noun) – domain, field, area, sphere, territory क्षेत्र
28. **Platonic** (noun) – non-romantic, spiritual, affectionate, pure, ideal गैर-यौनिक
29. **Go by** (phrase) – follow, consider, accept, rely on, adhere to मानना
30. **Paraphrase** (verb) – restate, reword, rephrase, express differently, summarize भावानुवाद करना
31. **Shrug off** (phrasal verb) – dismiss, ignore, reject, overlook, brush aside अनदेखा करना
32. **Nudge-nudge-wink-wink** (adjective) – suggestive, playful, flirtatious, implicit, allusive इशारोंभरी
33. **Baggage** (noun) – burden, emotional load, issues, hang-up, past trauma भावनात्मक बोझ
34. **Flutter** (verb) – flicker, quiver, tremble, flick, beat lightly हल्का कंपन होना
35. **Grace** (noun) – elegance, dignity, charm, politeness, refinement गरिमा
36. **Camaraderie** (noun) – friendship, companionship, fellowship, brotherhood, mutual trust मित्रता

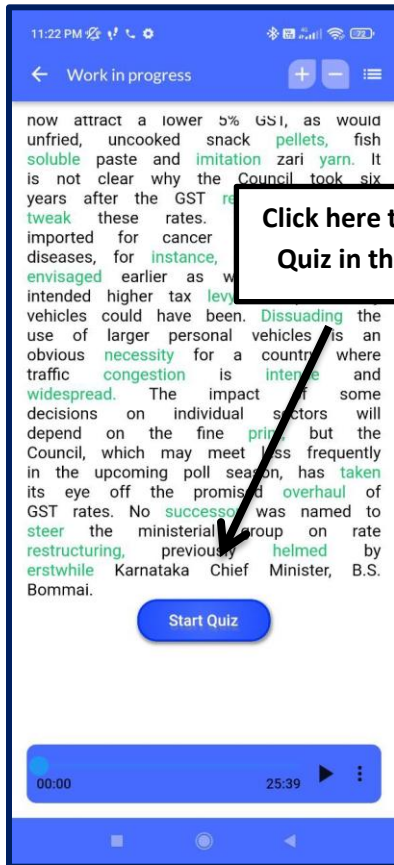
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



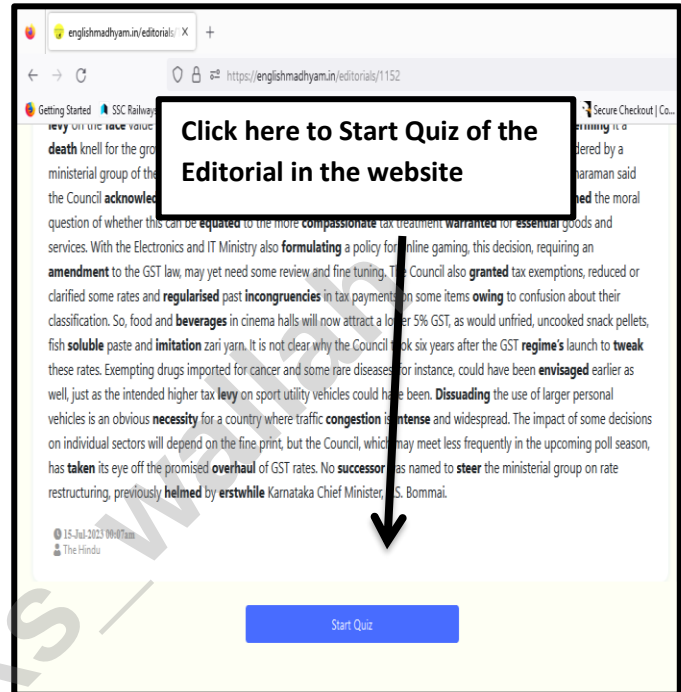
Summary of the Editorial

1. Oscar Wilde's quote — *"Between men and women there is no friendship possible..."* — has long echoed in society and pop culture, especially Bollywood, promoting the idea that friendship between men and women always hints at romance.
2. The idea is popularly reinforced by the Bollywood dictum: *"Ek ladka aur ladki kabhi dost nahin ho sakte"*, shaping how generations perceive cross-gender friendships.
3. Such beliefs portray male-female friendships as inherently unstable — *doomed, delicate, or secretly romantic*.
4. A recent NYU Stern–Meta study challenges this notion by analysing 1.8 billion friendships in nearly 200 countries.
5. The study reveals that genuine male-female friendships do exist, especially in societies with strong gender equality.
6. The more a culture moves away from traditional gender roles, the more natural platonic friendships between men and women become.
7. These findings connect with feminist history, especially with Mary Wollstonecraft, who in the 18th century, promoted cross-gender friendship as revolutionary and emotionally equal.
8. Wollstonecraft saw such friendships as the foundation of happy marriages, going beyond just physical attraction.
9. A century later, feminism tried to separate sex from friendship, promoting platonic bonds, though popular media has largely failed to normalize this.
10. Nora Ephron's *When Harry Met Sally* famously echoed the idea that *"the sex part always gets in the way"*, reflecting society's continued confusion.
11. The editorial asks a bold question — *What if sex didn't get in the way?* Could true friendship flourish then?
12. In modern, gender-equal spaces, cross-gender friendships show values like respect, empathy, and emotional openness.
13. While physical attraction may exist, mature friendships are capable of absorbing and moving past it gracefully.
14. The study emphasizes that affection doesn't need to become romance — it can stand alone as camaraderie.
15. Ultimately, the editorial suggests that a happy ending doesn't always require romance — genuine friendship is a powerful and equally fulfilling "happily ever after."

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



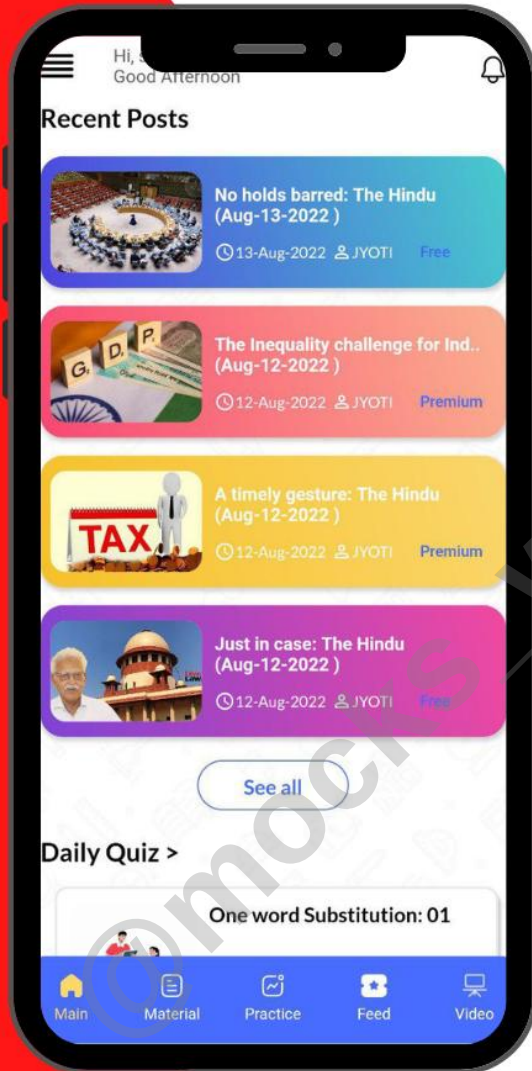
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